

only wrecking his finances, but steadily driving a wedge between him and his wife. The outside symptom (danger sign) was an indulgent attitude, but the Bible speaks of the real problem: "Poverty and shame will come to him who neglects discipline, but he who regards reproof will be honored" (Proverbs 13:18). Here was a man without control over his impulses.

Your indulgences may not run to steam locomotives. Few people's do. Instead it may be new cars, clothes, motor homes, jewelry, boats, stereos, or any of the myriad of things we can spend money on today. But if you recognize this danger sign in your marriage, stop and get counsel—right away.

DANGER SIGN: PARENT LOANS

Another danger sign in your marriage is when you frequently require your parents to bail you out of financial messes. Too often in this generation young people are not accountable for their decisions. If you get into trouble through overspending, get yourselves out. Don't let somebody else, especially a parent, bail you out. It's called "biting the bullet." It may mean tearing up your credit cards, cutting back on your spending, staying home, and even selling the new car if you have to.

Many times I've seen a marriage dissolve because the wife came from a fairly affluent family that fed her money indiscriminately. With the best of intentions, her parents usurped her husband's authority and supported an artificial lifestyle.

With rare exception, a man will resent it. Why? Because in his own eyes it lowers his self-esteem. And whether a wife admits it or not, it often lowers her esteem of her husband. It is through the problems, many times, that we mature. At least that's what James told us: "Consider it all joy, my brethren, when you encounter various trials, knowing that the testing of your faith produces endurance" (James 1:2).

Sometimes God will allow problems for the purpose of perfecting your marriage and your faith. It gives you a common bond that will draw you together.

As I look at our marriage, I think it has been the problems